490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 6 OF 26

Abraham: The Call and the Covenant

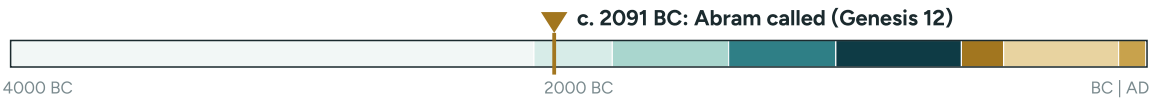
Genesis 12; 15; 22



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 6



Introduction: One Man, Every Family

When a rescue team searches a flooded city, they do not try to lift the whole town at once. They go house by house, one boat at a time. Last week we saw the whole human race scattered at Babel, every family on earth under the curse and spreading out across the world. You might expect God's next move to be something enormous: a voice from heaven to every nation, a sign in the sky. Instead, Genesis 12 zooms in on one old man in one city, with a wife who could not have children.

That is how God chose to rescue the world. Through one man, then one family, then one nation, and finally through one Offspring of that family, the blessing would reach "all the families of the earth" (Gen. 12:3). Every page of the Bible from here to the end of Revelation is the story of how God kept the promises he made to this man. His name was Abram, later Abraham. Jews, Christians, and Muslims all claim him as a father. The New Testament says who his children are: "it is those of faith who are the sons of Abraham" (Gal. 3:7).

This lesson opens Unit 2, "The Promise." We are at about 2091 BC on our timeline, when Abram was seventy-five years old. And three scenes in his life give us the shape of the gospel: a call, a covenant, and a mountain.

The Word: Believed, Counted

> **Genesis 15:5–6** *"And he brought him outside and said, 'Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them.' Then he said to him, 'So shall your offspring be.' And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."*

הֶאֱמִן ... וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ *(he'emin... wayyaḥshebeha)*

"he believed... and he counted it"

אָמַן ('aman)

"to be firm; to trust"

To hold something firm and reliable, to trust it. It is the root of our word *amen*. Genesis 15:6 is the first time the word "believe" appears in the Bible.

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חָשַׁב (ḥashab)

"to count, to credit"

A word for thinking or regarding, and also for reckoning something to someone's account (Lev. 7:18; Num. 18:27). Paul hears the accounting sense (Rom. 4:4–5).

Payoff: Abram did not earn righteousness by working for it. He leaned his whole weight on God's promise, and God credited righteousness to him. Paul builds his whole explanation of the gospel on this one verse: "to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness" (Rom. 4:5). This is what the Bible calls *justification*, and the Shorter Catechism defines it this way: "an act of God's free grace, wherein he pardoneth all our sins, and accepteth us as righteous in his sight, only for the righteousness of Christ imputed to us, and received by faith alone" (WSC 33). "Imputed" is the same accounting idea: credited to us. Faith receives that righteousness; it does not supply it. The Confession says God justifies us, "nor by imputing faith itself, the act of believing... as their righteousness; but by imputing the obedience and satisfaction of Christ unto them" (WCF 11.1). Abram was justified the same way, looking ahead to the Christ we look back on: "The justification of believers under the old testament was... one and the same with the justification of believers under the new testament" (WCF 11.6). In *Seventy Times Seven* I wrote about the ledger we keep against each other. God keeps books too, and Romans 4 shows what he does with them: he will "not count" our sin against us (Rom. 4:8), and he writes on our side a righteousness we never earned.

Part One: The Call

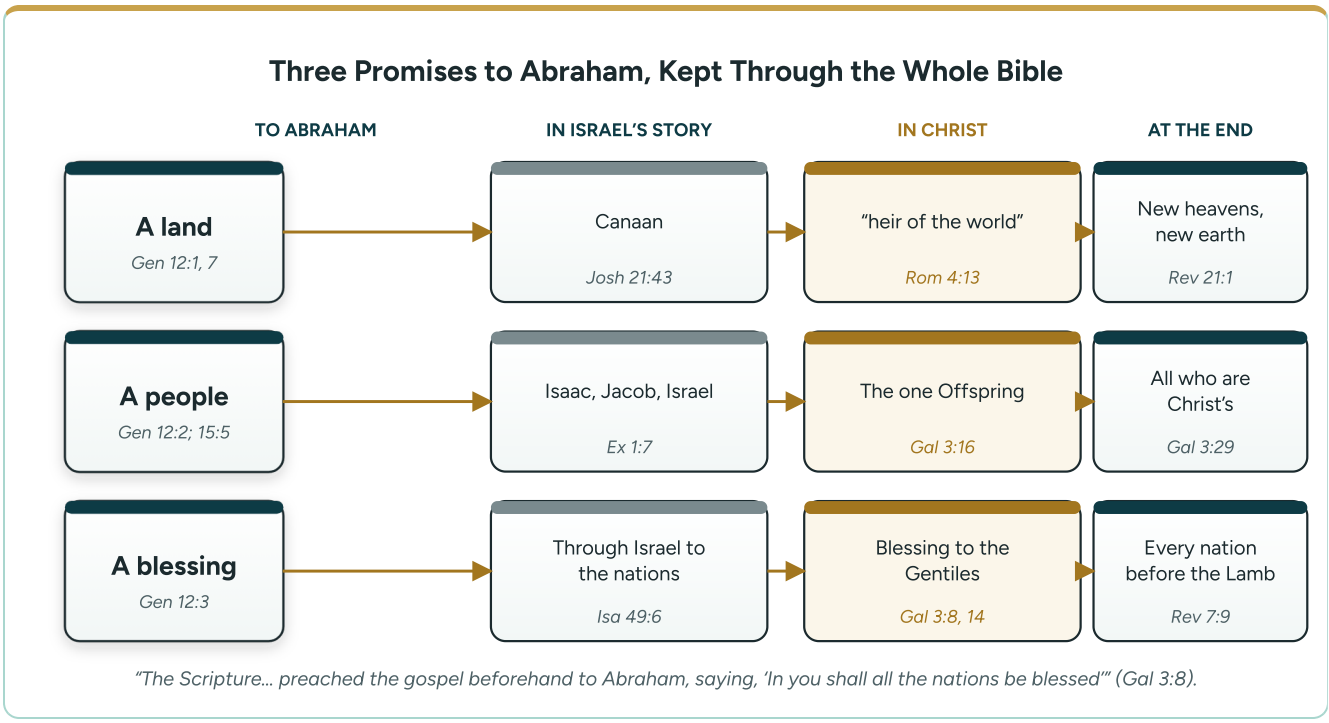
Abram grew up in Ur of the Chaldeans, a wealthy city in southern Mesopotamia, in what is now Iraq. His family moved north to Haran (Gen. 11:31). Genesis does not mention it, but Joshua does: Abram's family worshiped idols. Through Joshua, God reminded Israel, "Long ago, your fathers lived beyond the Euphrates, Terah, the father of Abraham and of Nahor; and they served other gods" (Josh. 24:2). God did not choose Abram because he was already seeking God. God came to an idol-worshiper's son and called him. Stephen says, "The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham when he was in Mesopotamia" (Acts 7:2).

> **Genesis 12:1–3** *"Now the LORD said to Abram, 'Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you. And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great, so that you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you, and him who dishonors you I will curse, and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.'"*

Look at what God asks and what God promises. He asks Abram to leave everything familiar for a land he has never seen. And he promises three things that run through the rest of the Bible like three strands of one rope: **a land** ("the land that I will show you"), **a people** ("a great nation," which means offspring, though Abram and Sarai had no children), and **a blessing** that would spill over to "all the families of the earth." Remember Babel, where people tried to make a name for themselves? Here God says, "I will… make your name great."

Paul says something stunning about this promise: "the Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham, saying, 'In you shall all the nations be blessed'" (Gal. 3:8). (Gentiles is the Bible's word for the nations, everyone outside Abraham's family line.) Genesis 12 is the gospel in seed form. One day, through Abraham's family, the blessing would reach every nation on earth.

"So Abram went, as the LORD had told him" (12:4). He was seventy-five years old. Hebrews says he "went out, not knowing where he was going" (Heb. 11:8). Faith follows the One who called even when it cannot see the destination.



"The Scripture… preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham, saying, 'In you shall all the nations be blessed'" (Gal 3:8).

But do not make Abram a superhero. Almost as soon as he arrived in the land, a famine drove him down to Egypt, and he was afraid the Egyptians would kill him to take his beautiful wife. So he told Sarai to say she was his sister (12:10–13), and she was taken into Pharaoh's house. The father of faith lied to save his own skin and put his wife in danger. God had to step in and rescue her. Genesis is honest about its heroes, and that honesty is good news. God's promises rested on God's faithfulness, not Abram's.

Part Two: The Covenant

Two things happened first. Abram and his nephew Lot had grown so rich in flocks that they parted ways, and Lot chose the well-watered plain near Sodom, whose men "were wicked, great sinners against the LORD" (13:13). When raiding kings carried Lot off, Abram armed his household and rescued him. On the way home a mysterious priest-king named Melchizedek, king of Salem, "brought out bread and wine" and blessed Abram, and "Abram gave him a tenth of everything" (14:18–20). Remember that name. Hebrews will call Jesus "a high priest after the order of Melchizedek" (Heb. 5:10).

Years passed, and still no child. Abram came to God with an honest complaint: "O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless" (15:2). God took him outside under the night sky and said, "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them… So shall your offspring be" (15:5). An old man with no children, looking at the stars. And the next sentence is one of the most important in the Bible: "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness" (15:6).

Then God did something strange and wonderful. He told Abram to bring a heifer, a goat, a ram, and two birds, and to cut the animals in half and lay the halves facing each other in two rows (15:9–10). In the ancient world, this was how people "cut a covenant." The one making the promise would walk between the pieces, and the meaning was a solemn oath: may I become like these animals if I break my word. Jeremiah describes the same ceremony and its meaning: God would make covenant-breakers "like the calf that they cut in two and passed between its parts" (Jer. 34:18).



"When the sun had gone down and it was dark, behold, a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces" (Gen. 15:17).

But look at who walked between the pieces. As the sun went down, a deep sleep fell on Abram (15:12). And in the darkness, "a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces. On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram" (15:17–18). Smoke and fire are signs of God's presence (later he will lead Israel by a pillar of cloud and fire). God passed through alone. Abram was asleep. In effect, God took the whole oath on himself: may I be torn apart if this promise fails. God cannot die and cannot lie, and that is the point: the promise is as sure as God himself. (Some scholars read the scene more simply as God's presence sealing the covenant. Jeremiah 34 supports the oath reading.) Years later, after Moriah, God would say it out loud: "By myself I have sworn, declares the LORD" (Gen. 22:16). Hebrews explains, "since he had no one greater by whom to swear, he swore by himself" (Heb. 6:13).

That night God also told Abram the hard part. His offspring would "be sojourners in a land that is not theirs and will be servants there, and they will be afflicted for four hundred years," and then God would bring them out "with great possessions" (15:13–14). That is the story of the Exodus, which we will reach in Lesson 8. God told Abram what would happen to his family centuries before any of it happened.

The waiting went on. Sarai, still childless, gave Abram her servant Hagar to bear a child for her. Other records from that world show the practice was accepted, but it was an attempt to get the promised child by human planning, and it brought nothing but pain (Gen. 16). Hagar bore a son, Ishmael (16:15). Abram loved him and pleaded, "Oh that Ishmael might live before you!" (17:18). But God said the covenant would go through the son Sarah would bear (17:19–21). After Isaac was born, Ishmael was sent away, and God promised to make a nation of him too, "because he is your offspring" (21:12–13). Isaac was the one son of the promise. When Abram was ninety-nine, God renewed the covenant, changed his name from Abram ("exalted father") to Abraham ("father of a multitude"), changed Sarai's name to Sarah, and gave the sign of circumcision, the cutting away of the foreskin, for every male in his household (17:1–14). Paul explains that sign carefully: Abraham "received the sign of circumcision as a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith while he was still uncircumcised" (Rom. 4:11). For Abraham, the sign came after his faith and sealed it. God also commanded that his sons receive it at eight days old (17:12), because the promise was "to you and to your offspring after you" (17:7). Either way, it pointed to the righteousness that comes by faith.

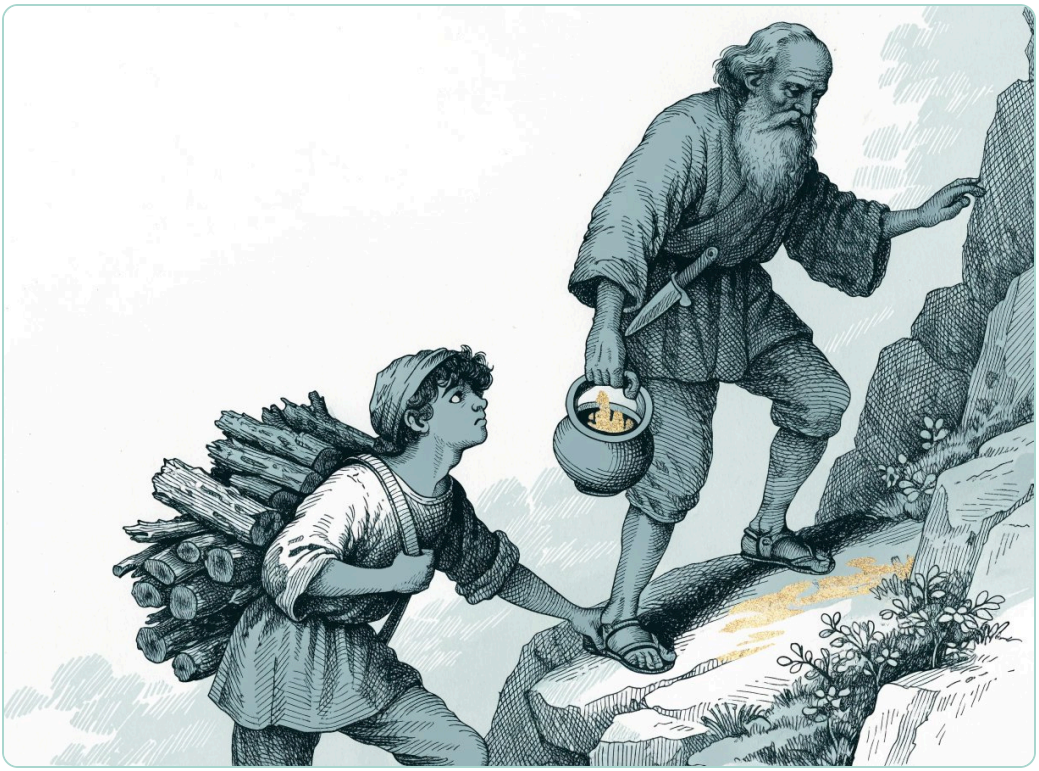
And then, at last: "Sarah conceived and bore Abraham a son in his old age at the time of which God had spoken to him… Abraham was a hundred years old when his son Isaac was born to him" (21:2, 5). They named him Isaac, which means "he laughs." Sarah said, "God has made laughter for me" (21:6). Twenty-five years after the call, the promised son arrived.

Part Three: The Mountain

> **Genesis 22:1–2** *"After these things God tested Abraham and said to him, 'Abraham!' And he said, 'Here I am.' He said, 'Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.'"*

This is one of the hardest chapters in the Bible to read, and you should feel its weight. God had given Abraham everything in this son: every promise of a nation, every hope of blessing to the world. Now God says, give him back. "Your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love." Each phrase presses harder. (A burnt offering was an animal killed and burned whole on an altar, given entirely to God.)

Before you think God was asking for what he hated, notice two things. First, Genesis tells us from the first line that this was a test (22:1). God never intended Isaac to die, and he stopped it. Later God would forbid child sacrifice as something he hates (Deut. 12:31) and say of it, "which I did not command, nor did it come into my mind" (Jer. 7:31). Moriah is the one time he asked, and he asked as a test that he himself stopped. Second, Abraham did not obey in despair. He told his servants, "I and the boy will go over there and worship and come again to you" (22:5). *We* will come again. Hebrews explains what Abraham was thinking: "He considered that God was able even to raise him from the dead" (Heb. 11:19). Abraham believed God would keep his promise about Isaac even if it took a resurrection.

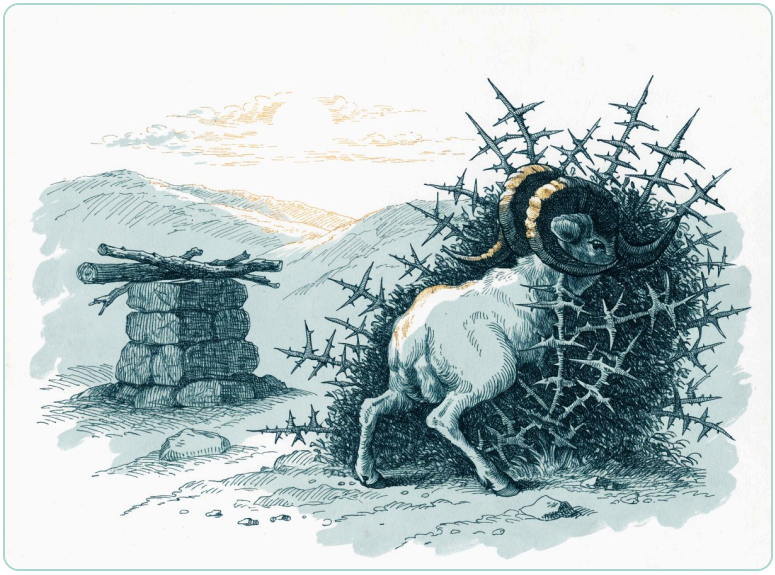


"And Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son. And he took in his hand the fire and the knife. So they went both of them together" (Gen. 22:6).

On the third day they saw the place. Abraham laid the wood on Isaac, and the two of them climbed together. Then the boy asked the question that echoes through the whole Old Testament: "Behold, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" And Abraham answered, "God will provide for himself the lamb for a burnt offering, my son" (22:7–8).

At the top, Abraham built the altar, laid the wood, bound his son, and raised the knife. And the angel of the LORD called from heaven: "Abraham, Abraham!… Do not lay your hand on the boy or do anything to him, for now I know that you fear God, seeing you have not withheld your son, your only son, from me"

(22:11–12). This angel is no ordinary messenger. He speaks as God himself: “you have not withheld your son… from me” (22:12), and then, “By myself I have sworn, declares the LORD” (22:16). Many Christian teachers, from the early church through the Reformers, have seen him as the Son of God appearing before he was born in Bethlehem. Scripture does not say so outright, so hold it carefully. Abraham looked up, and “behold, behind him was a ram, caught in a thicket by his horns. And Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering instead of his son” (22:13).



“Behold, behind him was a ram, caught in a thicket by his horns” (Gen. 22:13).

“Instead of his son.” Write those four words somewhere you will see them. Back in Eden an animal died to cover shame (Gen. 3:21). Here the Bible spells out the words: a substitute died in the place of the one who was supposed to die. “So Abraham called the name of that place, ‘The LORD will provide’; as it is said to this day, ‘On the mount of the LORD it shall be provided’” (22:14).

A word for later, when you read the letter of James. James says Abraham was “justified by works when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar” (James 2:21). That sounds like a contradiction of Genesis 15:6, but James quotes Genesis 15:6 himself and says Moriah “fulfilled” it (2:23). He is answering a different question. Paul asks how a sinner is declared righteous before God, and answers, by faith alone. James asks how you can tell faith is real, and answers, by what it does. Abraham was counted righteous by faith in Genesis 15, decades before Moriah. On Moriah his faith showed itself to be the real thing (James 2:22). Faith alone justifies, but justifying faith is never alone (WCF 11.2).

Two Mountains: Moriah and Calvary

	Isaac on Moriah		Jesus at Calvary
Only son	"your only son Isaac, whom you love" (Gen 22:2)	→	"his only Son" (John 3:16)
Carried the wood	laid it on Isaac his son (Gen 22:6)	→	"bearing his own cross" (John 19:17)
The lamb	"God will provide for himself the lamb" (22:8)	→	"Behold, the Lamb of God" (John 1:29)
A substitute	a ram "instead of his son" (22:13)	→	Christ died for us (Rom 5:8)
The father	"you have not withheld your son" (22:12)	→	"did not spare his own Son" (Rom 8:32)
Back from death	received back, "figuratively" (Heb 11:19)	→	raised on the third day (1 Cor 15:4)

On Moriah the knife stopped and a ram died instead. At Calvary no one stopped it, because he was the Lamb.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Everywhere Abram went, he built an altar and "called upon the name of the LORD" (Gen. 12:7–8). He never owned a house in the promised land. He lived in tents, "looking forward to the city that has foundations, whose designer and builder is God" (Heb. 11:10). And the mountain where God provided the ram? More than a thousand years later Solomon built the temple "on Mount Moriah" (2 Chron. 3:1). Jewish and Christian readers have long taken them as the same place.

THE LAMB "Where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" Isaac asked. "God will provide for himself the lamb," Abraham answered (Gen. 22:7–8). That day God provided a ram. But the question was still hanging in the air two thousand years later, when John the Baptist saw Jesus and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29).

The Turn: He Did Not Spare His Own Son

Read Genesis 22 again with the New Testament in your hand, and you will see a picture you cannot unsee. A father takes his only beloved son up a mountain. The son carries the wood for his own sacrifice up the hill. Centuries later, another Son would go out "bearing his own cross" to a hill outside Jerusalem (John 19:17). The son goes with him. The father raises the knife.

But on Moriah, the knife stopped. A ram died instead of Isaac. On Calvary, there was no voice from heaven to stop it, and no ram in the thicket. Because Jesus was the Lamb God had promised to provide. Paul draws the line from one mountain to the other: "He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up

for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" (Rom. 8:32). Abraham's son was spared. God's own Son was not (Rom. 8:32). The substitute that Moriah pointed to was the Son himself, dying "instead of" us.

Jesus said, "Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see my day. He saw it and was glad" (John 8:56). Abraham looked forward to the promised Offspring. We look back. And God counts righteousness to us the same way he counted it to Abraham, through faith in the promised Offspring. Paul says the words "it was counted to him" were "not written for his sake alone, but for ours also. It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification" (Rom. 4:23–25).

This is the invitation of Genesis 15 and 22. You cannot work your way into God's favor any more than Abram could produce the promised son by his own plan. He tried, with Hagar, and it brought only pain. You can only believe the promise and lean your whole weight on it. The Catechism describes saving faith as a grace "whereby we receive and rest upon him alone for salvation, as he is offered to us in the gospel" (WSC 86). Turn from your sin and from trusting yourself, and rest your whole weight on Jesus, who died and rose again. God will count you righteous for his sake. And "if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise" (Gal. 3:29).

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the three scenes.** Read Genesis 12:1–9, 15:1–21, and 22:1–19. Mark every promise God makes.

2. **Count the stars.** Go outside one night this week and try to number the stars, as Abram did. Thank God that his promises to you are as sure as the ones he made to Abram.

3. **Name your Haran.** What is God calling you to leave behind to follow him? Write it down and pray about one step of obedience.

4. **Hold loosely.** What gift from God are you tempted to love more than God himself? Give it back to him in prayer, trusting that he provides.

5. **Say "amen" on purpose.** Next time you say "amen" at the end of a prayer, remember it comes from the same root as "believed." It says, "This is sure, and I am resting on it."

6. **Memorize Genesis 15:6.** "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

Before Lesson 7: *Read Genesis 25:19–34, 28:10–22, 32:22–32, 37, and 45. Lesson 7 follows the promise through Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph, a family as messy as any of ours.*

For Discussion

1. God chose to rescue the world through one man and one family. Why do you think he worked that way, instead of all at once?
2. Abram's family "served other gods" (Josh. 24:2). What does it tell you about grace that God called Abram before Abram was looking for him?

3. Abram lied about Sarai in Egypt. Why do you think Genesis tells us about his failures? How does that encourage you?
4. In the covenant ceremony of Genesis 15, only God passed between the pieces. What does that say about who is responsible for keeping God's promises?
5. "Believed… counted it to him as righteousness." In your own words, what does it mean to be justified by faith?
6. Look at the Moriah and Calvary diagram. Which parallel between Isaac and Jesus strikes you most, and why?
7. Romans 8:32 says that if God did not spare his own Son, he will "graciously give us all things." Where do you need to trust that promise this week?

Sources & For Further Study

- Westminster Shorter Catechism (1647), Q. 33 (justification) and Q. 86 (faith in Jesus Christ). Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), chapter 11, "Of Justification."
- On אָמַן and חָשַׁב: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v.
- On the covenant ceremony of Genesis 15: O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants*; Meredith G. Kline, *By Oath Consigned*.
- For further reading: Derek Kidner, *Genesis* (Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries); John Calvin, *Commentary on Genesis*, on chapters 15 and 22; Timothy Keller, *Counterfeit Gods*, chapter 1 (on Abraham and Isaac).



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